EXAMPLE BRIEFING

podcast-generator

Listen to the research first, then decide what to read

Markdown script
plain text you or an AI assistant writes

→

Local text-to-speech
Kokoro, on your own computer

→

MP3 or narrated MP4
ready for the commute

This video was made by podcast-generator from the PDF and script in the examples folder.

WHY

Too many papers, not enough reading time

- A **7-minute audio explainer** is enough to decide whether a paper deserves a full read.
- Listening fits time that reading can't use: **a commute, a walk, the gym.**
- podcast-generator turns a written script into spoken audio **locally**: no API key, no per-use cost, and scripts never leave your machine.

HOW IT WORKS

A script goes in, audio comes out

1. Script

A markdown file. Plain paragraphs are spoken; headers and notes are not.

→

2. Convert

Kokoro text-to-speech reads it in the voice you choose.

→

3. Listen

An MP3 lands in your outputs folder.

Three ways to run it

From a chat
An AI app such as Claude Desktop writes the script and runs the conversion through the MCP connector.

Watch folder
Drop a script into a folder; a scheduled task converts it (Windows).

Command line
`podcast-generator talk.md`

FROM A CHAT

Ask for a podcast in plain language

Find a recent, technical paper on why language models improve with more data, and make me a 7-minute podcast about it for tomorrow's commute.

I picked “Deriving Neural Scaling Laws from the Statistics of Natural Language” (ICML 2026). I wrote a script, queued it, and started the conversion.

Done. `neural-scaling-laws-language-statistics.mp3`, 7.4 minutes, is in your outputs folder.

Illustrative exchange with an AI assistant that has the podcast-generator connector, condensed from a real session.

THE SCRIPT

Plain markdown, with notes that stay silent

```
# Where Scaling Exponents Come From

**Voice:** af_heart
**Link:**
https://arxiv.org/abs/2602.07488

## INTRO

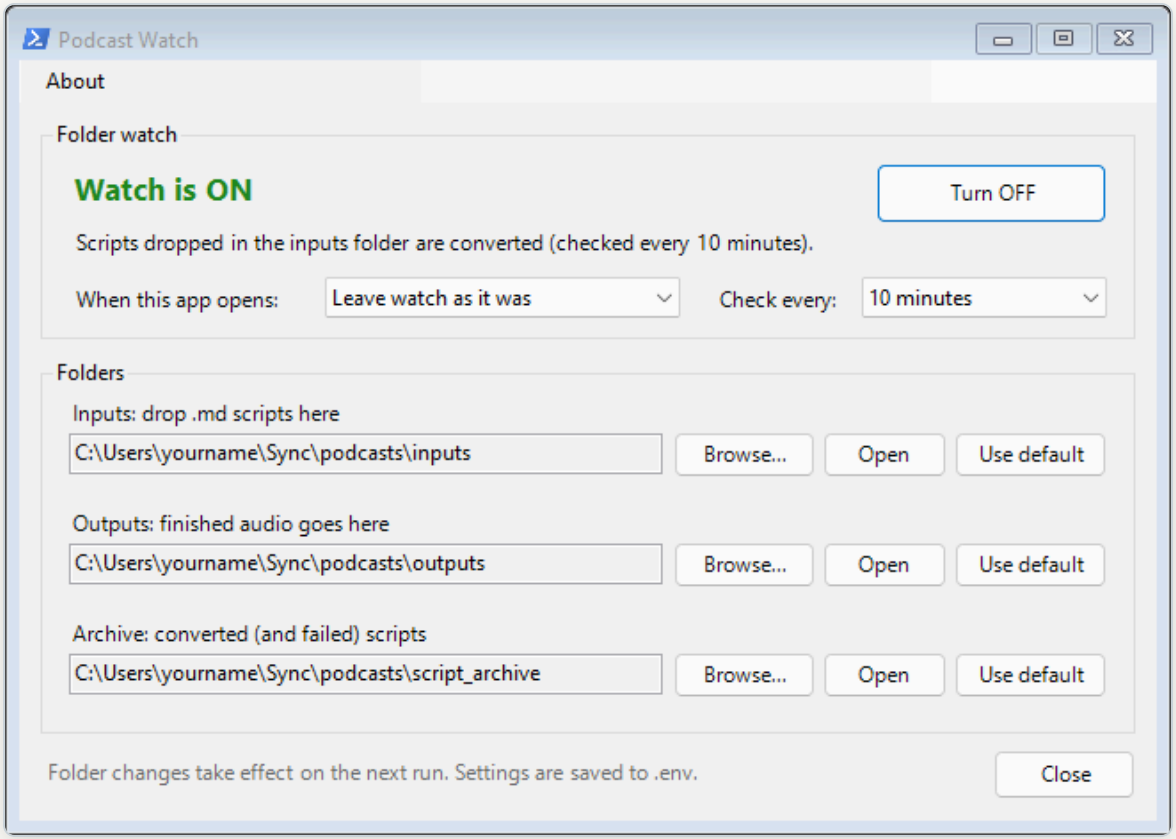
Anyone who follows language models has
seen the plots: test loss falls as a
power law in the amount of training
data.

*Source: Cagnetta et al., ICML 2026.*
```

- **Spoken:** ordinary paragraphs.
- **Not spoken:** headers, `**Key:** value` lines, rules, and italic-only lines.
- A `**Voice:**` line picks the voice.
- **Option:** a `**Voices:**` line turns it into a conversation between two or more speakers, each with their own voice.
- A lexicon file fixes how acronyms are pronounced.

FROM A PHONE

The watch folder: drop a script, get audio back

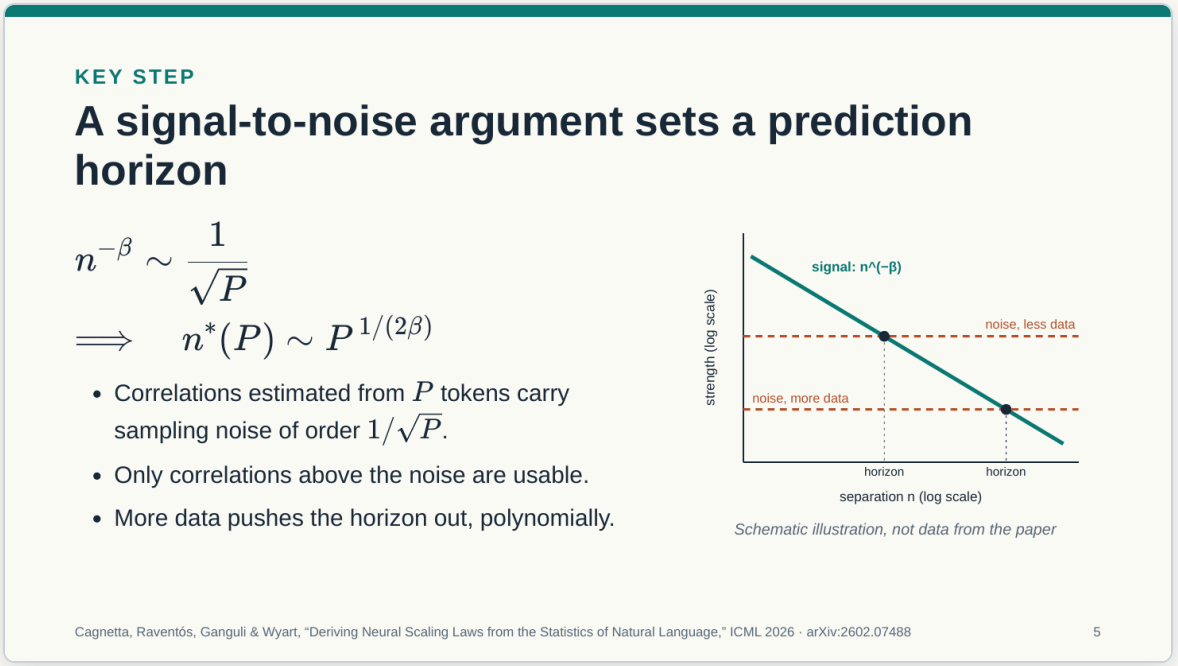


The Podcast Watch app (Windows)

- Point the inputs and outputs folders at a **cloud-synced folder**.
- Save a script there from **any device**, including a phone.
- The watch checks every 5 to 60 minutes, converts what is new, and archives the script.
- The audio syncs back to your phone the same way.

THE LIMIT OF AUDIO

Some papers need to be seen



KEY STEP

A signal-to-noise argument sets a prediction horizon

$$n^{-\beta} \sim \frac{1}{\sqrt{P}}$$

$$\Longrightarrow \quad n^*(P) \sim P^{1/(2\beta)}$$

- Correlations estimated from P tokens carry sampling noise of order $1/\sqrt{P}$.
- Only correlations above the noise are usable.
- More data pushes the horizon out, polynomially.

Schematic illustration, not data from the paper

Cagnetta, Raventós, Ganguli & Wyart, "Deriving Neural Scaling Laws from the Statistics of Natural Language," ICML 2026 · arXiv:2602.07488 5

A page from a narrated briefing on a mathematical paper

- Podcasts work well for surveying **most** papers.
- They work poorly when the argument lives in **equations, charts, or tables.**
- For those, make a **narrated briefing**: each page of a PDF is shown while its narration is read.

NARRATED BRIEFINGS

A PDF plus a page-marked script makes a video

```
# Quarterly review

**Briefing:** q3-review.pdf

## Page 1

Welcome to the quarterly review.

## Page 2

Costs went down this quarter.
```

- A `**Briefing:**` line names the PDF.
- A `## Page N` line starts each page's narration.
- Output: a 1920×1080 **MP4**, subtitles, and a timing file.
- **Strict by design:** a missing or mismatched page marker stops the run with a message, so you never get a wrong video.

HOW TO MAKE ONE

Two ways to make one

Ask your AI assistant

“Make a narrated briefing video of this paper.”

It builds the slides as a PDF, writes the narration for each page, and makes the video through the connector.

Or build the pieces yourself

1. Export your slides to PDF, from PowerPoint for example.
2. Write the narration, a `## Page N` line per page, or pull it from speaker notes with `--extract-notes`.
3. Run `podcast-generator deck.md`, or drop the script and PDF into the watch folder. `--preview` checks the timing first.

> Set up once: `pip install "podcast-generator[briefing]"` and ffmpeg.

BEFORE YOU INSTALL

What you need first

- **Python 3.10 or later.** It does not come with Claude or Claude Desktop; install it yourself, or use the uv installer, which can fetch Python for you.
- **About 2 GB of disk space and a one-time download** for the speech model and its libraries. It runs on an ordinary CPU; no GPU is needed.
- **ffmpeg** on your PATH: usually needed for MP3 output, and always for narrated briefings.
- **Internet for the first run,** when the voice model downloads. After that it works offline.
- **Windows** for the Podcast Watch app. The command line runs on other systems too.
- **Claude Desktop,** or another MCP-capable app, only if you want the chat connector.

GET STARTED

Install it and try the examples

```
pip install podcast-generator
```

- **Add-ons:** `[mcp]` for the chat connector, `[briefing]` for narrated videos.
- **Examples folder:** the script and PDF behind this video, plus a sample podcast script.
- **Documentation:** README for a quick start, MANUAL for the full guide.

> github.com/brienalkire/podcast_generator